And, while a truly secure and verifiable U.S.-Soviet agreement eliminating nuclear weapons by the year 2000 was something I wanted, too, what about the Qaddafis of the world, or a lunatic who got his hands on an A-bomb?

The Strategic Defense Initiative, if it proved practical, would give us the insurance we needed even after we had banned nuclear weapons—and on this, I decided, Gorbachev was up against an immovable object.

This is part of the entry in my diary for February 4, 1986:

> NSPG time in the situation room re Gorbachev's proposal to eliminate nuclear arms. Some wanted to tag it a publicity stunt. I said no. Let's say we share their overall goals and now want to work out the details. If it is a publicity stunt this will be revealed by them. I also propose that we announce we are going forward with SDI but if research reveals a defense against missiles is possible, we'll work out how it can be used to protect the whole world not just us.

Two days later, I sent another handwritten letter to Gorbachev, replying to both his Christmas Eve letter and his mid-January proposal. After chiding him for making public his letter to me, I said I was pleased we were approaching a common ground on the intermediate-range missiles and I hoped remaining problems dealing with verification of an INF agreement could be worked out shortly. I wrote that I agreed with him that we had to make decisions not on the basis of each other's assurances or intentions but with a cold-eyed regard for the capabilities of both sides.

> Nevertheless, I do not understand the reasoning behind your conclusion that only a country preparing a disarming first strike would be interested in defenses against ballistic missiles. If such defenses prove feasible in the future, they could facilitate further